CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

OCCUPATIONAL THERAPIST IN THE AI ERA

Not fixing bodies in the abstract — rebuilding the everyday acts a life is made of.

★ TL;DR — Median $100,330 with +15% growth and ~10,000 openings a year (BLS), on a 4+ year path: bachelor's, a 2–3 year accredited OT master's or doctorate with fieldwork, the NBCOT exam and a state licence — required in all states. The catch: graduate debt is real, so the school's price tag matters as much as its ranking. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

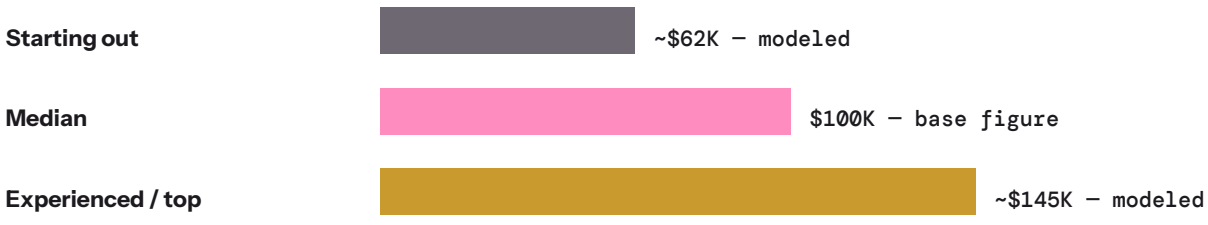
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$100K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- The old $75K figure was the occupation's ~10th percentile, not its market: the verified median is $100,330, growing +15% on an aging population's rehab demand.
- The moat is statutory and physical: all states require licensure, and evaluation and plan-of-care are legally reserved to the OT. AI generates documentation drafts under clinician oversight — nothing more.
- The route is 6–7 years in total (bachelor's + a graduate programme with at least 24 weeks of full-time fieldwork). Priced honestly here as a 4+ year study path.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Occupational Therapist is a ~$100K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A OCCUPATIONAL THERAPIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Evaluate what a patient can and can't do in daily life after injury, illness or disability
- ✓ Design interventions: retraining tasks, adaptive equipment, home modifications
- ✓ Run sessions from hand therapy to life-skills practice with kids and adults
- ✓ Document functional progress and coordinate with the care team and family

Think: an engineer of ordinary life — the project is someone's Tuesday morning working again.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Note generation, standardized assessment scoring and activity libraries are automating the paperwork and the generic suggestions. Head-to-head evidence rates AI drafts strong on completeness — with the clinician verifying, deciding and signing.	Watching a real person struggle with a real zipper, kitchen or classroom and inventing the adaptation. Context is the treatment.

⚠ **Graduate tuition is heavy — run the debt against the verified $100,330 median, not the old $75K ghost and not a recruiter's top-decile story. Productivity-driven settings can shrink creative work into quota visits. Choose setting and school cost deliberately.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Creative problem-solving disguised as therapy ✓ Populations from NICU babies to stroke survivors ✓ Daytime hours in schools and many clinics	✗ Explaining what OT is — forever, to everyone ✗ Graduate debt that demands a real repayment plan ✗ Emotionally demanding cases: disability, dementia, loss

Good fit? Inventive, patient and observant — you notice how people do things and how a small change could unlock them.
Bad fit? You want a short runway or purely physical, measurable work.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — BACHELOR'S, THEN A MASTER'S IN OT	DOOR B — OT ASSISTANT FIRST (COTA)

Complete a bachelor's with the prerequisite sciences, then an accredited master's (or entry-level doctorate) in occupational therapy with fieldwork. Pass the national NBCOT exam and get your state license before practicing.	Become a certified occupational therapy assistant through a shorter accredited program, work the field, then bridge to a full OT master's with experience and income behind you.

Smart move: Log volunteer and observation hours in two different settings (e.g. pediatrics and rehab) before applying — it sharpens both the application and your setting choice.
Where you land after: Occupational therapist → specialty practice (hands, pediatrics, neuro), school-system roles, program leadership — or an independent practice.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP PROGRAMS	BUILD THE	OBSERVE IN	COMPLETE THE	PASS BOARDS,	CHOOSE SETTING

STEP 1 — Map programs and costs

FREE · TODAY

- List accredited OT master's programs, prerequisites and total tuition.
- Read your state's OT license requirements end to end.

STEP 2 — Build the undergraduate base

YEARS · FOUNDATION

- Bachelor's degree with anatomy, psychology and statistics prerequisites.
- Keep grades strong — graduate admissions are selective.

STEP 3 — Observe in real settings

WEEKS

- Shadow OTs in two different settings; schools expect documented hours.
- Aide or rehab-tech work doubles as observation and income.

STEP 4 — Complete the graduate program

GRADUATE · 2–3 YEARS

- Coursework plus at least 24 weeks of full-time Level II fieldwork across populations.
- Choose final fieldwork in the setting you want to be hired into.

STEP 5 — Pass boards, get the state license

EXAM FEE · AFTER GRADUATION

- Pass the national OT certification exam (NBCOT).
- Apply for and receive your state occupational therapy license — mandatory to practice.

STEP 6 — Choose setting over salary at first

JOB HUNT · 2–6 WEEKS

- First job mentorship beats a small pay edge in this field.
- Specialize after a year of broad practice.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: list accredited OT programs, total costs and prerequisite gaps.
- □ Days 1–30: arrange observation hours in two settings; start missing prerequisites.
- □ Days 31–60: shadow shifts completed or underway; application timeline drafted.
- □ Days 61–90: aide/volunteer role started if possible; target schools narrowed by debt math.
- □ Day 90: you're on the graduate pipeline with hours logged and costs understood — no surprises.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **INDEPENDENCE IS A SKILL.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.